

Fenech

BAD BUSINESS IN TICKET OFFICE: A chain of questionable executive hires has led to a mass exodus of employees and experience on the Tigers business side: 88 employees have left the organization's business side since Chris Ilitch took over as chairman after his father's death in 2017. These departures are particularly noticeable in the ticket department, where current and former employees allege and describe a culture of sexism, employee mistreatment and uncomfortable working conditions. The data supports this description and points to a pattern: Since 2019, nearly 70% of the 41-person staff has departed; of the 10 female ticket sales employees who left, nine were in their 20's and all left within nine months of Chris Granger's second swing-and-miss at a big hire. Granger, hired to lead Ilitch's sports and entertainment group, first hired Roderick Emmons in 2018 as director of suite sales and service. Four days before he was introduced to the staff on Jan. 26, Emmons was arrested for allegedly masturbating in a pair of Troy department stores. According to multiple current and former employees, the Tigers were not aware of this until weeks later, perhaps not until March 5, when news reports surfaced of a charge of two counts of indecent exposure. Improbably, Granger's second hire was worse: Dave Baldwin, a 31-year-old executive who came from the Miami Dolphins to lead both the Tigers and Red Wings' ticket departments. Baldwin's aggressive leadership style immediately clashed with employees. His domineering personality affected females especially, but not exclusively. According to multiple current and former employees, Baldwin is alleged to have: Made disparaging and derogatory comments about employees' physical appearances in both public and private situations with co-workers; placed uncomfortable pressure on employees about their personal lives and job performance in group settings; asked a female employee to change from a professional work attire into a dress before a client prospecting event; and offered preferential treatment and sales leads to female employees due to their physical appearance.

What we should be able to report:

- That nearly 90 employees of the Tigers business side have left since 2017;
- That 38 ticket department employees have left since 2017 and nearly 70% of the ticket department staff left in 2019;
- That the departures of young female ticket department employees in 2019 is indicative of a sexism problem;
- The number of female managers and executives compared to male

What we may be able to report:

- That HR has ignored employees' complaints about this treatment;
- That a Tigers spokesperson lied about Emmons' length of hire with the organization;
- That Baldwin also made an inappropriate comment to a Black female Red Wings ticket department employee.
- That this culture extends beyond the ticket department
- That the ticket department also has a diversity problem

What we have done:

- Contacted 45 current or former employees on the Tigers business side; including 19 current and former ticket department employees;
- Identified the 88 employees who have left the Tigers business side since 2017;
- Compiled demographic data including age and experience of all employees who have left;
- Corroborated allegations of employee treatment with multiple persons with first-hand knowledge;
- Corroborated allegations of unfair practices in compensating and setting commission rates with multiple former ticket department employees;
- Filed a FOIA with the Troy Police Dept. about Emmons' arrest in Jan. 2018.

Who we have spoken with:

- 28 current and former employees on the Tigers business side, including one former Ilitch Holdings executive;
- 19 current and former ticket department employees, including one former executive;
- 11 current and former female employees on the Tigers business side, including seven current and former female employees in the Tigers ticket department.

Who has not spoken to us:

- 16 other current and former Tigers business side employees, including three current or former executives;
- 11 current and former female employees on the Tigers business side, including nine current and former female employees in the ticket department.

Who we have yet to speak to:

- Seven other current and former Tigers business side employees, including five current female employees in the ticket department; Multiple current and former executives and employees in the Red Wings ticket department.

Other sources:

- Internal company emails;
- Employee e-mails to HR;
- Other current and former employees on the Tigers business side;
- Public records.

What we have left:

- Contacting more current and former Tigers business side employees, including all current and former ticket department employees;
- Strengthening sourcing with more executive-level confirmation of allegations;
- Strengthening sourcing with current or former female ticket department employees providing on-record accounts;
- Speaking with other executives in the professional sports' ticket sales industry to compare commission practices;
- Research the ticket industry on demographic data to put the departures in perspective.

Bonus material:

- An explainer story on what the ticket department means to a professional sports team;
- A sidebar on the challenges of Ilitch's attempt to combine MLB (81 home games) and NHL (41 games) ticket departments;
- An audio story on the investigative story;
- A column about why this matters to the public - a question asked to many people in the process.

In addition: The reporting and execution of this story should lead to other fires inside the Ilitch sports empire, including a similar culture inside the Red Wings ticket department, the big diversity problem that the Tigers have and a look at how the future of Ilitch's ownership of both teams will shake out.

Another potential story:

THE TIGERS DIVERSITY PROBLEM: The Detroit Tigers, an institution in the nation's city with the largest Black population, have one Black baseball operations official: Franchise figurehead Willie Horton, who works as a special assistant to general manager Al Avila. There are two members of the Avila family on the staff, including Avila's son, Alan, who is the team's assistant legal counsel. The Tigers have not had a Black baseball operations official since Ricky Bennett as director of minor league operations in 2003, according to the team's media guides. "There can't be a diversity problem if there is no diversity," one current employee said. In the past three years, the remaining longtime Black officials on the business side have left. After Horton, the next longest-tenured Black employee is XXXXXX. There are two black women in prominent positions: On July 24, I received an unsolicited screenshot between a pair of Detroit PAL executives, with a note that Jordan Field, the Tigers director of player relations and the Detroit Tigers Foundation was, "Specifically looking for African American / diverse children to feature in a Zoom video on the Comerica Park scoreboard". Two days later, I received an internal e-mail from a Tigers marketing employee to an executive, disappointed in management's decision to not mention the Black Lives Matter cause publicly. Before the Tigers' Opening Day game against the Reds, both teams knelt around the field, holding a black rope: Only two teams did not mention the Black Lives Matter cause, including the Indians. In 2018, the Tigers fired pitching coach Chris Bosio after allegations of making racially insensitive comments to a Black clubhouse attendant. Last year, the team was sued for racial discrimination, alleging that the Tigers promised a baseball operations internship to this person, who is diagnosed with Asperger's syndrome, before pulling it from him. In mid-June, after notifying my assigning editor,

I sent questions to Avila regarding the team's diversity in baseball operations and the steps they may be taking to address it. These questions went unanswered.